Chatbot Options in Zoho

The options Zoho offers today, how each one works, and why none of them fits our course-advisor chatbot

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What we need

A chatbot on the DataSphere website that can:

- Answer **any question about our courses** (content, duration, fees, prerequisites, batches).
- **Understand the visitor**: ask about their background, skills and goals in a natural conversation.
- **Suggest the right courses** or a learning path for that particular person.
- **Capture interested visitors as leads** in Zoho CRM for the sales team.

Below are the chatbot options Zoho currently provides, checked against these needs.

All options at a glance

#	Option	Where it lives	Main problem for us
1	Codeless Bot Builder (Zobot)	SalesIQ (website chat)	Fixed script, can't hold a real conversation
2	Answer Bot	SalesIQ / Zoho Desk	Only repeats FAQ articles, can't recommend
3	SalesIQ Scripts (Deluge)	SalesIQ	Everything must be hand-coded in Zoho's language; no real AI
4	Zia Skills	SalesIQ	Built for simple fixed tasks, not open-ended advising
5	Webhooks	SalesIQ	Not a bot by itself; we must build the AI anyway
6	Watson / Azure Bot	SalesIQ + IBM / Microsoft	Needs a separate paid bot platform we don't have
7	Zia in Zoho Desk	Zoho Desk (support tickets)	Made for after-sales support, not for new visitors
8	Zoho Cliq bots	Zoho Cliq (team chat)	Internal only; students never see it

Background: Zoho's website chat product is **SalesIQ** (the chat bubble on a website). A bot inside SalesIQ is called a **Zobot**. When creating a Zobot, Zoho asks you to pick a *platform*, which decides how the bot's brain works. Options 1 to 6 are those platforms.

1. Codeless Bot Builder (Zobot)

What it is

A drag-and-drop tool inside SalesIQ for building a bot without code. You draw the conversation as a flowchart.

How it works

- You add blocks such as "send message", "ask name", "show buttons", "if answer is X go to Y".
- The visitor mostly clicks buttons; the bot follows the exact path you drew.
- It can collect details (name, email, phone) and push them to Zoho CRM.
- It can be started based on page, country or campaign, and can hand over to a human.

Example: "Welcome! Choose: [Courses] [Fees] [Talk to counselor]". This works, but only for questions we predicted.

Why we can't use it for the DataSphere course bot

- It is a **fixed script**. It cannot understand free sentences like "I'm in 3rd year ECE, I know a bit of Python, what should I learn?"
- To "recommend" courses we would have to draw a branch for every combination of background, skill and goal, which is impossible to maintain.
- Every time a course, fee or batch changes, the flowchart has to be edited by hand.
- Visitors who type something unexpected get stuck or get a generic "I didn't understand".

2. Answer Bot

What it is

Zoho's ready-made bot that answers questions by searching the company's help articles / FAQs (knowledge base). Available in SalesIQ and in Zoho Desk. Newer versions use Zia's AI to rephrase the answer from the matching article.

How it works

- The team writes FAQ articles in Zoho's knowledge base.
- A visitor types a question; the bot finds the closest article.
- It replies with that article's answer (or a link), optionally rewritten by AI.
- If nothing matches, it can pass the chat to a human.

Good at: "What are your office timings?" **Bad at:** "I know basic Python and want a data job in 6 months, what should I do?"

Why we can't use it for the DataSphere course bot

- It only **repeats what is written in articles**. It does not reason or compare.
- It **cannot ask follow-up questions** about the visitor's background and goals.
- It **cannot give personal recommendations** ("which course should *I* take?") or build a learning path.
- We would have to rewrite all course information as many separate FAQ articles and keep them updated.
- Optional ChatGPT fallback sends our data to a third party and can answer outside our course data.

3. SalesIQ Scripts (Deluge)

What it is

A Zobot whose behaviour is written as code in **Deluge**, Zoho's own scripting language, inside the SalesIQ editor.

How it works

- Zoho runs our script on events: when the chat starts, when the visitor sends a message, when something fails.
- The script decides what to reply, which buttons to show and what to save.
- It can call Zoho CRM and other Zoho apps directly.

Why we can't use it for the DataSphere course bot

- It is **not AI**. Deluge only does what we code with if/else rules, so understanding questions and recommending courses would all be hand-written logic.
- Deluge is Zoho-only; the code can't be reused anywhere else and few developers know it.
- Adding a real AI model from inside Deluge is possible only through outside API calls, which is basically building our own AI bot anyway, with a harder language and editor.
- Harder to test, debug and version-control than normal code.

4. Zia Skills

What it is

Lets you teach Zoho's AI assistant **Zia** specific "skills" (tasks) that it can perform in chat.

How it works

- You define a skill, e.g. "book a demo" or "check order status".
- You give example sentences that should trigger it, and the details (parameters) it must collect.
- When a visitor's message matches, Zia runs that skill, often backed by a Deluge script.

Why we can't use it for the DataSphere course bot

- Designed for **fixed, task-style actions**, not open-ended advice.
- Each skill must be defined by hand; it does not read our course catalog and reason over it.
- Cannot hold a flexible, multi-turn counselling conversation that ends in a personal course suggestion.
- Limited control over how Zia phrases answers or keeps to our data.

5. Webhooks

What it is

A Zobot where SalesIQ is only the chat window. Every visitor message is forwarded to **an external server we own**, and our server sends back the reply.

How it works

- Visitor types in the SalesIQ chat bubble.
- SalesIQ sends the message to our server's web address.
- Our code decides the reply and sends it back; SalesIQ shows it to the visitor.

Why we can't use it for the DataSphere course bot

- **It is not a bot.** It is just a pipe. The brain (AI, course data, recommendations) still has to be built by us.
- So it doesn't save the main work. It only replaces the chat window, while adding a dependency on a paid SalesIQ plan and Zoho's message format.
- **Note:** this is the only Zoho option that could work *together with* our own AI later, if the team wants SalesIQ's live-agent handoff. It is a connector, not a solution.

6. Watson Assistant / Azure Bot Service

What it is

Lets SalesIQ use a bot already built on **IBM Watson** or **Microsoft Azure**.

How it works

- The bot is built and hosted on IBM's or Microsoft's platform.
- SalesIQ connects to it and shows its replies in the website chat.

Why we can't use it for the DataSphere course bot

- We don't have a Watson or Azure bot; we would have to build one there first.
- That means paying for and learning a **second, separate bot platform** on top of Zoho.
- These are intent-based bot builders: they still need hand-defined intents and flows, so they share the same "can't truly advise" problem.

7. Zia in Zoho Desk

What it is

AI built into **Zoho Desk**, Zoho's customer-support helpdesk (where complaints become "tickets").

How it works

- Zia's Answer Bot answers customers on the help center from knowledge-base articles.
- It can fall back to ChatGPT if the admin connects it.
- It helps support staff: suggests replies, summarises tickets, detects customer mood, finds missing articles.

Why we can't use it for the DataSphere course bot

- Built for **existing customers with problems** ("I paid but can't access my course"), not for **new visitors choosing a course**.
- Lives on the help center / ticket system, not as a sales assistant on the website.
- Same limits as Answer Bot: answers from articles only, no personal recommendations.
- Requires a Zoho Desk plan with Zia features.

8. Zoho Cliq bots

What it is

Bots inside **Zoho Cliq**, Zoho's team chat app (like Slack or Microsoft Teams) used by employees.

How it works

- Built with Deluge scripts or webhooks.
- Answer staff questions, send alerts (e.g. "new lead!"), run small internal tasks.

Why we can't use it for the DataSphere course bot

- **Internal only**: website visitors and students never see Cliq.
- Wrong audience entirely for a course-advisor bot.
- Could only be a small add-on later, e.g. alerting the sales team in Cliq when a new lead arrives.

Conclusion

Need	Code-less	Answer Bot	Scripts	Zia Skills	Web-hooks	Watson / Azure	Desk Zia	Cliq
Answer any course question	No	Partly	Coded by hand	No	Our code	Partly	Partly	No
Understand the visitor	No	No	No	Limited	Our code	Limited	No	No
Suggest right courses	No	No	Coded by hand	No	Our code	No	No	No
Capture leads in CRM	Yes	Limited	Yes	Yes	Our code	Via setup	No	No

None of Zoho's ready-made options can hold a natural conversation and recommend courses from our catalog. Zoho's bots are built for **fixed menus, FAQs and support tickets**, not for **personal course counselling**. The one option that gets close, Webhooks, is only a connector: the AI still has to be built by us.

> **Decision:** build our own AI chatbot that answers from DataSphere's course data (RAG) and recommends courses, and connect it to **Zoho CRM** so every interested visitor is saved as a lead. Zoho stays where it is strong (managing leads); our bot does the talking.

Sources

Zoho SalesIQ: Create a Zobot (platform list): https://www.zoho.com/salesiq/help/developer-guides/create-bot.html

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Zoho features change often; verify on Zoho's official pages before final decisions.